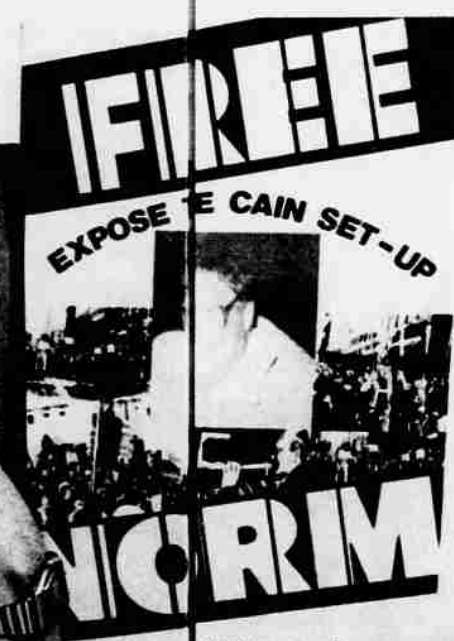




FOR KAVANAGH against all the odds.



BILL HARTLEY BINGLES ON

Bill Hartley, the eternal left-wing nemesis of the Labor Party, is on the rise again. KEITH DUNSTAN visited him in Melbourne.

YOU find Bill Hartley in a quite hideous building in Leveson Street, North Melbourne. There are signs offering out of date *Free Norm* T-shirts and *Free Norm* windcheaters. There are pamphlets on how to survive on the dole and the wonderful virtues of the 35-hour week. It is the headquarters of the Food Preservers Union and the headquarters of the extraordinary Bill Hartley.

A whole succession of Labor leaders — Gough Whitlam, Bob Hawke, John Cain — would have been delighted had it been possible at a snap of the fingers to turn Bill Hartley into a pillar of salt or, even better, send him as permanent Trade Commissioner to Baghdad, where just possibly he belongs. But nobody gets rid of Bill Hartley that easily. For more than 20 years he has moved forward almost like a Leopard tank, unbending. As he says, you can bend anything but a principle. Some can but not Bill. As a result he moves from barney to barney. Barney and bingle are favourite words for Bill and he's in them all the time.

He doesn't deny that he enjoys a barney or a bingle. It gets the adrenalin flowing.

It is fascinating to observe Bill Hartley. He has no parliamentary seat, he has no senior administrative post in the ALP. He is on the federal and national executives of the party and is chairman of several committees. His real power comes from being the spokesman for the Socialist Left, the one man capable of filling the role upon the departure of Dr Jim Cairns.

His office is a marvel of electronic clutter. He has an NEC lap computer. He has a Lanier word processor and three teleprinters, one pumping in the news from Australian Associated Press (AAP). Of course, he's the local representative for the Iraqi News Agency, so he has to keep up with the news.

He also has one of the telephones with a microphone so that he can sit back like

a chairman of directors, write and talk without a receiver in his hand.

One was intrigued to find out why a nice boy who went to some of the nicest church schools ended up as a champion of the radical Left.

Bill Hartley, who believes passionately in the 35-hour week, works 100 hours, is untidy, with sleeves rolled up and grey hair unused to a comb, and he has an interesting mouth. It tilts to port at an angle of 25 degrees.

Bill Hartley, you must understand, has been built up as the evil eye of the Labor Party. But he is charming. It's impossible not to like him. And he's very persuasive. Give him a Toyota agency and he would sell 20 Toyotas in an afternoon.

He was born in Southern Cross, Western Australia, in 1931. His father was born in England and migrated to Australia in 1927. He was a wheat farmer who failed during the depression.

"Actually he went to jail," said Bill. Bill Hartley always put things very directly. Bill explained that his father went bankrupt; he couldn't make the farm pay. The banks in those days didn't sell up the farms, there was no money in that. They kept the farmers on the land, took over their entire output and paid them an allowance.

"It was a miserable subsistence allowance," said Bill. "It wouldn't pay your tractor bill, or anything to keep the farm going. He was caught selling wheat; oh, everybody was doing it. He went to jail in Fremantle for six weeks." He was also a member of the WA Wheat Growers Union and the feeling was that the jailing was politically inspired.

They never went back to that farm. Bill's mother was a member of a conservative mining family and they helped Hartley senior train at the Bendigo School of Mines. Then he went off to BHP's Hannans North mine in Kalgoorlie as a mining engineer.

So young Bill went to school at the local Christian Brothers College. The Hartleys weren't Catholics but Christian Brothers was the nearest available private school. It was interesting that the man who became the arch opponent of State Aid for church establishments was educated entirely at private schools. There was a real division between the Hartleys. Bill's mother would never have dreamed of voting Labor. His father moved further and further to the Left. He was bitter about that jailing. He joined the RAAF in 1939, went away as

Bill Hartley: champion of the left

MICHAEL RAYNER